

Case Study: Zensar Technologies

Zensar Technologies, a software services company, is headquartered in Pune. The company's sales operations are globally distributed and the work takes place across different time zones. The problem that the company faced was two-fold.

The direct sales people required a pre-sales support that included updates on a client's background, expectation and need. On the other hand, sales personnel were hesitant to share their follow up of a client's information, but expected instant organisational support. To solve the

problem, the company installed the ACT! software in October 2003. The results have been more than satisfactory.

The software helped them handle both offshore and onsite activities better.

According to Shyam Kuddyady, head, enterprise pre-sales, Zensar, "The software has been a small investment, but it has brought a change in work culture. It has ensured a two-way communication between the sales and the support team." For Zensar, the software was all about reliability and transparency of information.

matter, how about sales forecasting? This is where sales force automation comes in—it helps you automate anything and everything about the sales process.

SFA is often defined as a technique of using software to automate the day-to-day business tasks of sales. These tasks include contact management, order processing, customer management, information sharing, and order tracking. This apart, SFA even takes care of inventory control, sales forecast analysis and performance evaluation.

Ideally, marketing materials should be electronically forwarded to the sales force. With such a system in place, salespeople have the materials needed to promote the latest products and services, right at their beck and call. Prices and inventory can be checked on the spot, and orders can be taken and transmitted electronically. SFA software makes estimation of sales forecasts and expenses precise and brisk. The business organisation can even maintain client lists without creating much clutter, and meticulously analyse buying patterns.

SFA can revolutionise a business on the administrative front. Salespeople can electronically file their time sheets, which eventually makes it easy for management to track their performance. Similarly, managers can analyse buying trends and profitability, and fine tune marketing plans and product lines accordingly.

With all the nitty-gritty of an SFA environment dealt with, a bottomline clearly stands out. SFA drastically reduces the paperwork involved in the sales process. It also cuts down heavily on the time spent on paperwork. All this leaves the business more time and resources for actual sales.

However, the decision to deploy sales force automation can be fraught with risk, given that the software doesn't carry a clean slate. There is no "one size fits all" SFA solution, and there are several glaring stories of how SFA strategies have flopped. Reasons range from poor implementation of the systems, to insufficient training for the employees to handle the software well enough.

But implemented correctly, SFA brings

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home huge benefits for the business.

US-headquartered Phoenix Systems Integration recently conducted studies on successful implementations of SFA—the results say that proper implementation of the software pushes up revenues by 30 per cent. In fact, profits can shoot up even 60 per cent. These facts are proof enough of what SFA can do to your business.

ACT! 2005

Let's take a close look at ACT! 2005 Premium for Workgroups as an example of SFA software. Think of SFA software as Outlook on steroids. Only, it does much more. ACT! Premium gives you a powerful way to capture and share information in a collaborative environment.

You can find the trial version of ACT! on the Digit CD/DVD.

Contact and customer management is the process of capturing and managing every aspect of your business relationships, including

- Contact details
- Activity history and meeting notes
- E-mail and other correspondence
- Schedules, appointments and to-do items
- Proposals and reports
- Sales tracking and forecasting

The software stores detailed contact and customer information, including e-mail messages, history, attachments, activities, sales opportunities, etc.

You can find anyone or any detail easily by performing Lookups on any Field or by using the Keyword Searches. Lookups can also be saved as Groups.

For example, you can quickly define sales territories by performing a Lookup on State, and then you can simply save it for quick reference. This, in turn, gives your team a complete picture of the entire relationship.

ACT! creates and maintains detailed company records. All notes, histories and opportunities related to the company are stored in the same place. If core company information changes, each related contact gets updated. You can have Notes stamped with date and time, and History tied with each contact to keep track of important details, such as conversations and commitments.

ACT! includes features for individual as well

The screenshot displays the ACT! 2005 Premium for Workgroups interface. It features a sidebar with icons for Contacts, Tasks, Opportunities, and Reports. The main window is divided into several panes, including a 'Comprehensive contact data-base with more than 60 fields' at the top, a 'Task List' in the middle, and a 'Your team can view all sales opportunities at once' section at the bottom. Red arrows point from text labels to specific features in the interface:

- Comprehensive contact data-base with more than 60 fields**: Points to the top contact list area.
- The Task List gives a team a comprehensive view of what's on its plate**: Points to the central task list pane.
- Your team can view all sales opportunities at once**: Points to the bottom opportunities section.
- You can create, send and track e-mail using the ACT! E-mail Client**: Points to the email client icon in the sidebar.
- You can schedule activities, individually or for your workgroup**: Points to the 'Activities' icon in the sidebar.
- There are more than 40 standard reports**: Points to the 'Reports' icon in the sidebar.